



HOW TO ACCEPT BITCOIN AT THE POINT OF SALE

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Two paths, matched to what the merchant wants. “I want dollars” → **the Square path**. “I want bitcoin / sovereignty” → **the BTCPay path**. Both accept Lightning; both can be running the same day.

Educational only — not financial or tax advice. The Square click-path below is a fast-moving product — verify against [Square support #8622](#) the day you set it up.

PATH A — SQUARE (THE EASY ON-RAMP)

Best for: a shop that already uses Square, wants USD in the bank, and wants zero new hardware.

What it is: As of late 2025 / early 2026, Square accepts bitcoin over the **Lightning Network** natively. It was auto-enabled (opt-out) for millions of US sellers on Mar 30 2026. **0% processing fee through Dec 31 2026, then 1%.** New Jersey is supported; New York is not.

Know before you start: - **Caps:** ~\$600 per transaction, \$20,000 per day. Great for a café or bar; too low for big-ticket retail. - **Custody:** the Square bitcoin balance is **custodial** — Block holds the keys until you withdraw to your own wallet. If you choose USD settlement, this is moot. - **How the buyer pays — two paths:** (1) **Cashier-initiated (any supported device):** the cashier taps **Bitcoin** as the tender, Square shows a **Lightning QR**, and the customer scans it from **any Lightning wallet** (including Cash App, up to its \$999 / 7-day limit). (2) **Buyer-initiated (Square Register, new as of June 4 2026):** a “**Bitcoin**” button appears on the customer-facing display and the customer selects **Bitcoin themselves**, then scans the QR — or, on **Register 2nd-gen**, taps an NFC Lightning phone (no QR). The buyer-self-select button is **Square Register only** — not Terminal, Stand, or mobile. - **Refunds:** issued as a **gift card** for the equivalent dollar amount (not a bitcoin send-back). A sale that takes **more than 5 minutes is declined** and must be re-rung at the new rate. - **Tax doc:** Square provides the seller a **1099-DA**; you’re responsible for any capital gains/losses.

Steps (verify live — Square changes the UI): 1. Sign in to your **Square Dashboard** (or the Square POS app). 2. Go to **Settings** → **Banking / Payments** and find the **Bitcoin** section (Square may have already enabled it). 3. **Activate bitcoin payments.** Accept the terms. 4. **Choose your settlement:** *Convert to USD automatically* (recommended for simplest bookkeeping) or *Keep as bitcoin*. 5. Run a **test sale:** ring up a small amount, let Square display the Lightning QR, and pay it from a phone wallet. Confirm it lands. 6. If keeping bitcoin: set up a **withdrawal to your own wallet** (self-custody) so funds don't sit with Block.

What this means for your staff: On a **Square Register**, the customer taps "Bitcoin" on their own checkout screen and your team rings the sale exactly like a card — no transaction-type switching, nothing different to learn. On a Terminal/Stand/phone, staff tap "Bitcoin" once before presenting the QR. (Source: [Square release notes, June 4 2026](#) — Square frames this as removing the need to "manually switch the transaction type"; "no staff training" is our plain-language paraphrase, not a Square quote.)

PATH B — BTCPAY SERVER (THE SOVEREIGN PATH)

Best for: a merchant who wants **no fees, no KYC, and the money straight into their own wallet** — and is willing to let a JC Bitcoin volunteer do the setup.

What it is: free, open-source payment software. **Non-custodial** (funds go directly to the merchant's wallet via an xpub), **no processing fees, no ID/KYC**, supports Lightning + on-chain. Running it costs **~\$10–16/month** on a one-click host.

Steps: 1. **Pick a host.** For non-technical merchants, use a **web-deploy host** — LunaNode or Voltage — not a manual server build. (Self-hosting on your own node is the most sovereign option if you run one.) 2. **Deploy BTCPay** via the host's one-click installer. 3. **Create a store** and **connect the merchant's own wallet** by pasting its **xpub** (public key only — never a seed phrase). Payments now land directly in that wallet; BTCPay only watches it. 4. **Set up Lightning:** open the built-in Lightning node and fund a channel (or connect an existing node). *This + ongoing maintenance are the two real hurdles — the JC volunteer owns them.* 5. **Enable the Point of Sale app** (or Pay Button). This gives the merchant a tap-to-charge screen that generates a Lightning/on-chain QR per sale. 6. **Test** a small real payment end-to-end. 7. Optionally add **plugins** (tipping, inventory, shopify/woocommerce) later.

Reference: [BTCPay POS tutorial](#) · [BTCPay deployment docs](#).

PATH C — OPENNODE (ONLINE / E-COMMERCE)

Best for: a merchant whose sales are **online** — a web store, invoicing, or a developer build — not a card-counter shop. **OpenNode is a JC Bitcoin sponsor.**

What it is: a custodial Bitcoin + Lightning processor. Plugins for Shopify, WooCommerce, BigCommerce, Magento, PrestaShop, OpenCart; a hosted checkout + payment button; invoicing; and a REST API (Node/PHP). ~1% fee, no monthly/setup fees, free conversion. **Auto-converts to USD and pays out to a US bank** (US businesses only — a JC business qualifies). Custodial + KYC, like Square.

Steps (online store): 1. Sign up at [opennode.com](#) and complete **KYB** (business verification). 2. Set your **settlement:** USD (auto-convert to your bank), bitcoin, or a split. 3. Install the **plugin** for your platform (Shopify / WooCommerce / etc.) — no code — or use the **hosted checkout / API**. 4. Run a **test order** end-to-end.

Full rundown: [../business-kit/opennode-business-solution.md](#).

PICKING THE WALLET/PROCESSOR (US-USABLE ONLY)

Several popular “easy” Lightning wallets **block US users** — do not use **Wallet of Satoshi** or **Blink**; **IBEX** suspended US service in 2024.

WANT...	USE	NOTES
Dollars, easiest	Square or Strike	Strike pays out to a US bank via ACH; FDIC-insured USD balance.
A WoS-style app that works in the US	Speed	US-registered MSB. Confirm KYC thresholds at signup.
Self-custody on a phone	Phoenix or Breez	Phoenix returned to US app stores Apr 2025; Breez has a built-in POS mode.
Full sovereignty	BTCPay + own node	No fees, no KYC, your keys.

AFTER ANY SETUP — THE 4 FINISHING MOVES

1. **Add the business to [BTCMap](#)** so Bitcoiners can find it (free marketing).
2. **Put up a “Bitcoin Accepted Here” sticker** at the register.
3. **Brief staff (often nothing to train).** On a **Square Register** the customer self-selects Bitcoin on their own display — staff ring the sale like a card. On a Terminal/Stand/phone, leave one laminated card: *“Bitcoin? Tap ‘Bitcoin,’ customer scans the QR — their phone does the rest.”*
4. **Leave a support contact** — the single thing merchants value most is knowing they can text someone. Stand up a JC Bitcoin help channel and put it on the sticker.